'Yes, thank you very much, Mr Lorgat.'

After the call ended, I immediately phoned home to relay the news to my parents. Two years after leaving Affies, nine months after playing in the Tuks second team ... it was almost unbelievable.

Arriving at the first day of camp, I was a wreck.

'Hello, Mr Kallis.'

'Good morning, Mr Smith.'

'Hello, Mr Pollock.'

'Good morning, Mr Hall.'

'Hello, Mr Ntini.'

Everyone was kind, and I decided I would keep my head down, say as little as possible and try as hard as possible.

It was both exciting and terrifying to find myself suddenly included among this squad of heroes and legends, to be eating and training alongside players I had so much admired on television. I was suddenly painfully self-aware, worried about saying the wrong thing at the wrong time, fretting about who might happen to be standing in the lift when it opened in front of me, concerned about where I would sit at the table ... the opposite of the apparently self-confident, carefree Tukkies student who had spent so many happy hours, literally, in the bars half a kilometre from the High Performance Centre, cheerfully chatting to girls and ordering beers for my mates.

Now and then, I started to wonder what these established international cricketers thought of me. Did they notice me at all? Had they been told I was a cocky youngster who had no respect for the game? But time spent wondering is usually time wasted.

In that first week with the Proteas, I wanted to be nothing more and nothing less than myself, the product of my upbringing. Whether I stayed in the team for one Test or 100 Tests, I wanted to earn respect as a fighter, as a guy who never ducks a challenge, who always puts the team first and who is respectful to players and coaches, who always,